it, benevolence, compassion, and a benign attitude towards his fellow human beings seem to lie at the back of the assertion that Ashoka's Taxila campaign was nonviolent from start to finish.

But did Prince Ashoka ever actually come to Taxila? He himself never says he did, but that is neither here nor there because we have seen how famously reticent he was about his early life. Whoever composed the *Ashokavadana*, though, may have known that the city bore many markers associated with Ashoka. For one, the most impressive Buddhist monument of Taxila was a stupa whose name, Dharmarajika, alludes to Ashoka. The nomenclature denotes a religious structure built by the Dharmaraja of the Buddhists, the emperor Ashoka. So, the *Ashokavadana*'s account of its protagonist's visit to a turbulent Taxila squares with the archaeological evidence. For another, the title by which Ashoka was known in his edicts which figure a little later in the book, was used in an Aramaic inscription that was found at Taxila on an octagonal pillar of white marble. The epigraph mentioned 'our lord Priyardarshi'.[4] That this 'Priyadarshi' was Ashoka is evident from the nature of the message which speaks of non-injury to creatures and obedience to the aged.[5] In other words, Buddhists and others familiar with Taxila who may have read or listened to this nugget about Ashoka's early life are not likely to have doubted its veracity.

It is not as clear how the scribe who put together this legend of Ashoka's life would have visualized the city itself. Travellers frequently went to Taxila, a flourishing urban centre in the early centuries CE, and they may have carried back impressions of its big buildings and broad streets. But by then it was no longer situated where Ashoka had been: it stood in a different location, at Sirkap, towards the northern side of the valley, occupying a small but well-defined plateau there. The *Ashokavadana* contains nothing enlightening for those curious about this old city, nor about how it would have appeared to Ashoka, nor why its citizens had rebelled against his father. But this is because the work is purposive and agenda driven: it is